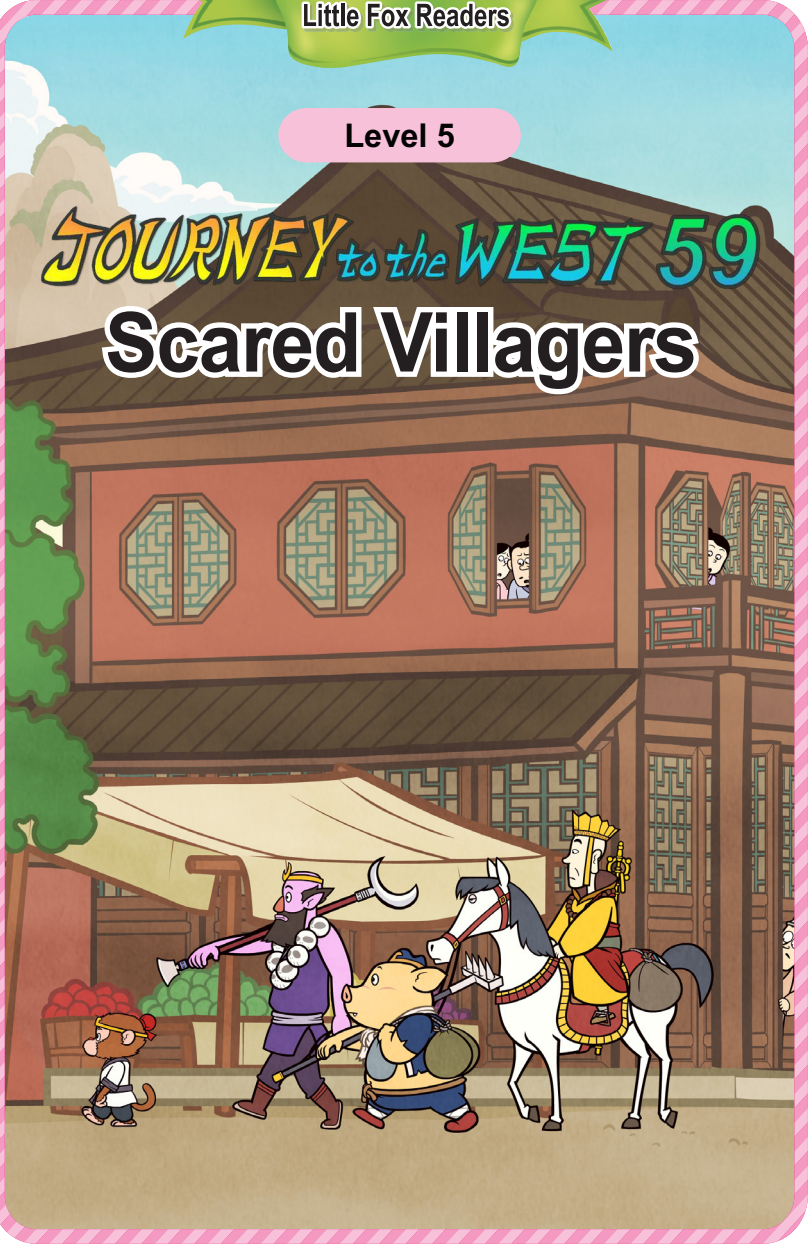
Little Fox Readers

Level 5

JOURNEY to the WEST 59

Scared Villagers



Little Fox



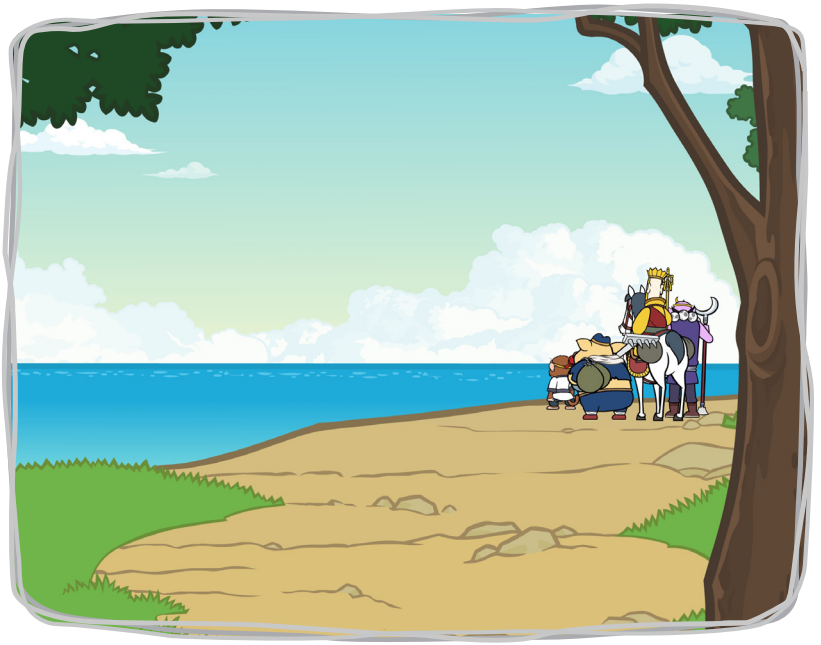
Can we please stop to rest?" moaned Bajie one day.

The group had spent the morning walking down a long mountain trail.

"My knees feel weak!" cried the pig.

"We'll rest in a little while, Bajie," said the Tang Monk.

As they walked, the travelers started to hear the sound of rushing water. It grew



louder and louder.

"We're approaching a river," said Wujing.

The trail went around a hill. A moment later the travelers saw the river.

"How will we cross this river?" said the Tang Monk. "It's so wide, I can't see the other side."

Wukong leaped into the air and looked around. "There's a small village nearby," he



said. “Maybe someone there has a boat.”

The group walked to the village. The street was deserted. A few villagers peeked out of windows and from behind doors. They looked scared.

A man was getting water from a well.

“Hello!” said Wukong.

Startled, the man dropped his bucket down the well and spun around. “Wh-who



are you?”

The Tang Monk stepped forward. “I’m from the Tang Empire. We’re traveling to the Western Paradise to get scriptures from Buddha.”

The man relaxed a bit. “That’s wonderful!”

“We need a boat to get across the river,” said Bajie.



“I don’t have a boat,” said the man. “But someone in the village might. Please come with me. I’ll make some tea. My name is Chen.”

The travelers followed Chen to his home. Inside, they sat down as Chen boiled water for tea.

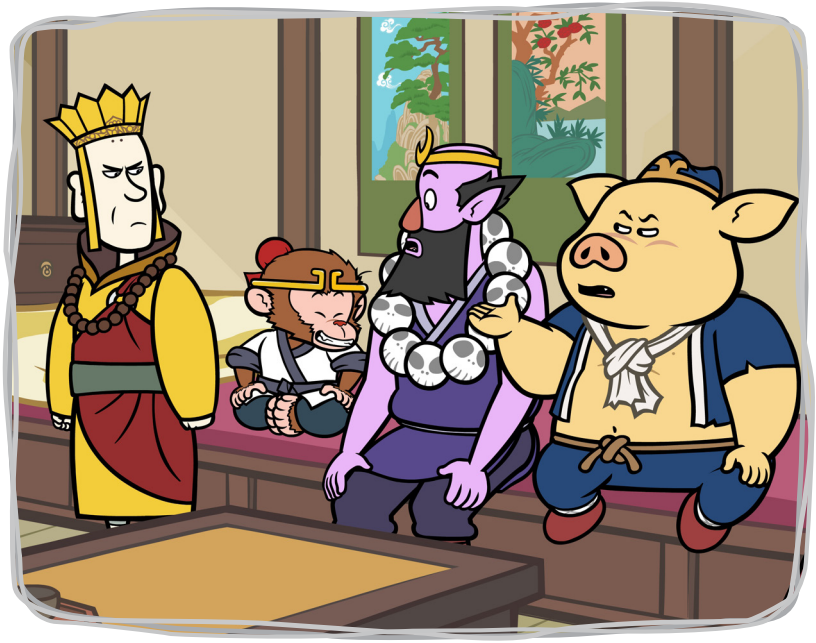
“Why does everyone in this village seem so scared?” asked the Tang Monk.



Chen sighed and sat down. He started to cry.

"My dear man," said the Tang Monk. "What's wrong? Did I upset you?"

"No," said Chen through his tears. "It's just that life is very bad in this village. A few years ago, a terrible demon arrived. He's always treated us badly, but now things are worse. He demanded that we give him a child.



If we don't, he'll destroy our entire village. Tomorrow morning I must . . . hand over my son!" Chen burst into tears all over again.

Wukong giggled and then laughed.

The Tang Monk glared at the monkey. "Wukong! Why are you laughing?"

Bajie shook his head. "He's cruel, Master. You should recite the Tight Headband spell."

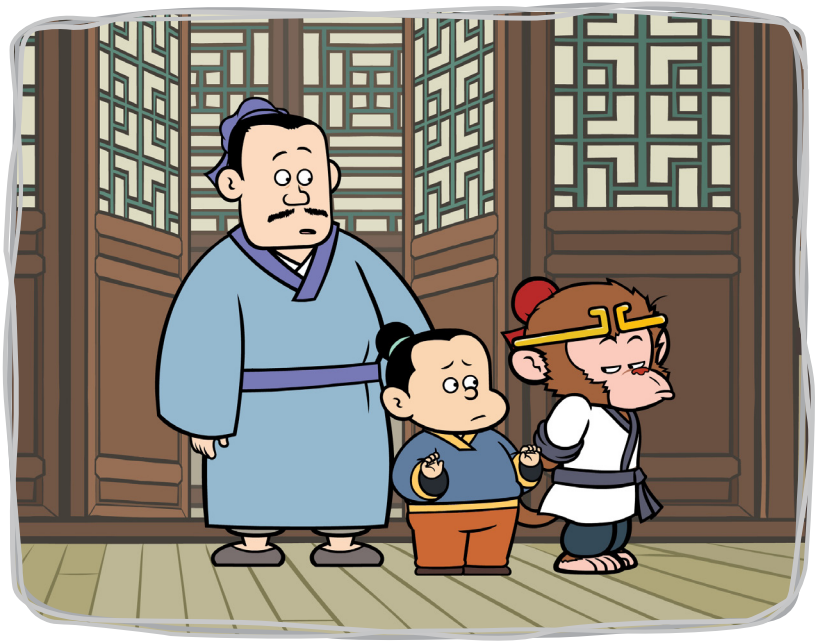
"There's no need for that," said Wukong,



still laughing. He turned to Chen. “I’m not laughing at you, sir. I’m laughing because today is the luckiest day of your life.”

Chen raised his eyebrows. “How am I lucky?”

“You’ve probably never heard of me,” said Wukong. “But I am Sun Wukong, the Monkey King. I once defeated the Jade Emperor’s entire army. And tomorrow I will



save your son's life."

"Are you a spirit?" asked Chen.

"Yes, a very powerful spirit," said Wukong. "Bring your son out here. I need to look at him."

Chen left the room for a moment. When he came back, a small boy was with him.

"This is my son," said Chen.

Wukong walked around the boy,



examining him closely. Finally the monkey folded his arms and said, “I have a plan.”

* * *

The next morning the boy climbed onto a small platform. Several villagers carried the platform to the edge of the river. They placed the platform on the ground and then backed away.



For a moment everything was quiet. The boy sat alone on the platform.

Suddenly a dark cloud approached. A fierce-looking demon emerged from the cloud. It had sharp teeth.

The boy smiled at the demon. “Hello!”away.

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Journey to the West 59
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